FOR THE TEACHER

Teacher Guide & Answer Key

What's in the Playlist? — AutoMix improv tips, a key or exemplar for every Playlist Check item, the real-world debrief, what-ifs, standards.

WHY THIS LESSON

Students usually hear "AI is biased" as "somebody made it mean." This lesson swaps the villain for a mechanism: **input → patterns → output**. Once a student has personally failed Tomás because their playlist held no Spanish tracks, "biased training data" stops being vocabulary and becomes something they *did* — and can fix. Every AI job runs **human → AI → human**: a person starts it, the AI does the middle from its playlist, and a person checks what comes back. A gap in the playlist is why that last human has to check.

PLAYING THE ONE-PLAYLIST APP

Three moves carry the bit: **serve with total confidence** (the app has no idea it's failing — never apologize), **announce the track like it's exactly right** ("Grandma's birthday? VOLUME WAR."), and **upgrade nothing** — a slow-song request gets the same tempo, cheerfully. Keep it to 3–4 requests. The gold moment: a student says the playlist is the problem, not the app. Hand them the imaginary aux cord — they just said the thesis out loud.

ANSWER KEY — SERVE THE REQUEST LINE (WORKSHEET P.1)

"Best card" can vary; the Fit ticks shouldn't drift far from these (scale: **Perfect fit · Kind of fits · Nothing fits**).

REQUEST	STRONG PICKS	EXPECTED FIT
1. Priya — hype song, team runs onto the court	Full Court Press, Crowd Goes Wild	Perfect fit
2. Nia — calm study music	Cool Down (Kinda)	Kind of fits, at best — medium, but still a loud party track
3. Tomás — song in Spanish	Any card (the app must serve)	Nothing fits — zero Spanish tracks
4. Keisha — slow last-dance song	Cool Down (Kinda)	Nothing fits — medium is not slow; nothing slower exists
5. Malik — first song of the party	Thunder Mode, Bass Quake, Confetti Cannon	Perfect fit
6. Jordan — quiet guitar song	Any card	Nothing fits — nothing quiet exists
7. Live request	Varies	Ask: what did the playlist do to it?

Why Cool Down (Kinda) is **Kind of fits** for Nia but **Nothing fits** for Keisha: "calm" is a mood the track half-has; "slow" is a tempo it simply isn't. If a pair ticks Nia as Nothing fits or Keisha as Kind of fits, don't correct it — ask them to defend it. The disagreement is the lesson.

SCORING — GAP REPORT, REPEAT THEN ADD, FIX THE PLAYLIST (WORKSHEET P.2)

- **Proficient:** names WHO is served and left out (people, not song types); say-back in the partner's words, add = a new gap or person; new cards target different gaps (tempo, language, style).
- **Developing:** names missing song types but not the people; the add repeats the say-back; new cards fix one gap two or three times.
- **Beginning:** "the playlist needs more songs," with no who and no what; no say-back before the add.

EXEMPLARS — EVERY WRITTEN ITEM (WORKSHEET P.2)

Gap Report 1 (who it serves well): "Priya and Malik — anyone who wants loud, fast, English party or gym music. The playlist has twelve songs for them."

Gap Report 2 (who it leaves out): "Tomás, Keisha, Nia and Jordan. Tomás asked for Spanish and got English; Keisha asked for slow and got medium; Jordan asked for quiet and got a stadium song."

Repeat, Then Add: "I heard you say the playlist has nothing in Spanish, so Tomás got a party song." / "Building on that, it also has nothing slow, so every request that isn't a party gets a party anyway."

Fix the Playlist: "Luna Lullaby — soft guitar ballad · slow · study" / "Cumbia del Cumpleaños — cumbia · medium · family party, Spanish lyrics" / "Porch Strings — folk · quiet · sing-along." Three cards, three different gaps.

Exit Ticket 1: "INPUT → PATTERNS → OUTPUT. The AI studies its playlist of examples, learns what usually goes with what, and answers by predicting what matches those patterns. It doesn't understand — it predicts."

Exit Ticket 2: "Whoever filled its playlist used football examples, so football patterns are all it can serve. Students whose interests never made the playlist get worse help." Look for WHO gets worse help, not just "needs more songs."

Exit Ticket 3: any real gap in the student's own words that names a person or request ("my partner noticed nobody could get a quiet song, so Jordan got a stadium track"). Not accepted: "more songs."

Support / ELL: add the frame "This playlist serves ____ but not ____." Overwhelmed by 12 cards? Pre-circle Cool Down (Kinda) and the three Gym tracks as landmarks.

THE REAL PLAYLISTS — DEBRIEF GUIDE (3 MIN)

Voice assistants: they understand best the voices that filled their training audio. Less-common accents, kids' voices and speech differences have been misheard more often — a gap that traces back to the playlist.

Photo tools: face-analysis tools have had higher error rates on darker skin when training photos leaned lighter (documented in 2018 research). The fix for a playlist problem is fixing the playlist — companies have since rebuilt datasets for exactly that reason.

Your feed: a recommendation app's playlist is millions of people's viewing behaviour; your own history is the *request*. Watch one genre and it matches you to the one-genre crowd — the same mechanism, in their pockets.

Handle with care: some students in the room are the people these gaps mishear or mislabel. Keep the frame "the playlist failed them, and playlists can be fixed" — never "the tech doesn't like you."

WHEN IT GOES SIDEWAYS

"Did someone do this on purpose?" → Usually not. Teams collect the data that's easiest to get, and easy data leans toward whoever is already common. No villain required — which is why good AI teams audit their playlists before shipping.

A pair argues about a Fit tick → both ticks go on their own sheets. Disagreement is data — bring it to the debrief: "Two honest raters, two answers. What does that tell you about the playlist?"

A pair writes "it needs more songs" → ask WHO asked for something that wasn't there. The standard (2-IC-21) is about people, not song counts.

Every new card is a slow song → "Which request still has nothing? Tomás?" Push for a different gap per card. If asked **"isn't AI creative?"** → it can mash up playlist patterns into new combos, but not a genre it has never heard.

FULL STANDARDS TEXT

- **CSTA 2-IC-21** — Discuss issues of bias and accessibility in the design of existing technologies. *Taught: Playlist Check gap-mapping + Real Playlists debrief. Assessed: Gap Report Q2 + Exit Ticket #2.*
- **ISTE 1.1.d** — Students understand the fundamental concepts of technology operations, demonstrate the ability to choose, use and troubleshoot current technologies and are able to transfer their knowledge to explore emerging technologies. *Taught: No Magic in the Machine (input → patterns → output). Assessed: Exit Ticket #1; transfer to a new tool in Exit Ticket #2.*
- **CCSS ELA SL.6.1** — Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions (one-on-one, in groups, and teacher-led) with diverse partners on grade 6 topics, texts, and issues, building on others' ideas and expressing their own clearly. *Taught: the repeat-then-add rule in Playlist Check step 3. Assessed: "Repeat, Then Add" + Exit Ticket #3.*

THANK YOU & TERMS OF USE

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